PRODUCT PLAN · 30 OCTOBER 2026

What Palmframe should take from OpenManga

OpenManga is a self-hosted studio for long AI comics and narrated videos. We reviewed its code and docs to find what is worth adding to Palmframe.

> **Recommendation:** borrow its ideas about trust and consistency, not its size. OpenManga is about 159,000 lines built for long productions on your own server. Palmframe is a hosted editor for short, swipeable comics, and that focus is an advantage.

The five moves that matter most

MOVE	WHY IT COMES FIRST
Add tests and CI	Palmframe has no tests and no CI, and it charges money. This comes before any new feature.
Check every panel	A vision pass catches wrong characters, and its face boxes make the next move possible.
Letter around faces	Tails point at speakers and bubbles stop covering faces: a large visual gain for little code.
Extend consistency	Add pose guides, outfits and locations. Keeping one world across slides is what people pay for.
Make work travel	Reader links and translated lettering spread each carousel further with no new image spend.

Our main lesson: OpenManga treats a story as structured data, and it never lets AI output become final until a person has seen it. Most of what follows comes from those two habits.

15
features proposed

3
foundation fixes first

4
phases, about 5 months

9
things to leave out

How to read this: we read OpenManga’s source and docs but did not run it, so its feature claims are its own. Effort and value ratings are our judgement. S is up to 3 days, M is 1 to 2 weeks and L is 3 weeks or more, for one person.

THE COMPARISON

Two products with different jobs

OpenManga has moved fast: it reached version 0.19.9 about six weeks after its repository was created on 16 September. It is young, with 14 stars and 1 fork, so treat it as a source of ideas and not as proof of what the market wants.

159k
lines of TypeScript

17
internal packages

183
test files, ours: 0

Apache-2.0
licence

	OPENMANGA	PALMFRAME
Made for	Long chapters, webtoons, YouTube recaps of up to 3 hours	Instagram carousels, Stories and short comics
Runs as	Self-hosted Docker stack with Postgres, Redis, workers, nginx	Hosted on Vercel with Supabase
Who pays for AI	Users bring their own provider keys	Credits via Stripe, or a connected OpenRouter account
Image models	Hosted APIs such as gpt-image-2 and Gemini	Anima Turbo and FLUX.2 Klein
Consistency	Versioned cast, outfits, locations, props and a story bible	Character sheets, a carousel-wide Look, and a recap of the previous slide
Quality checks	Vision check, continuity check, storyboard review	The user's own eyes
Editing	Page editor, masks, versions, panel shapes	Strong: masks, edit tools, restyle, upscale, versions, phone support
Publishing	Export files, reader links, YouTube stats	**Stronger:** posts and schedules directly to Instagram
Export	PDF, print, PSD and more, plus video	JPEG, PNG, WebP, PDF, PSD
Agents	Large MCP server with scopes and approvals	8 MCP tools, with estimate before spend

Where we already lead: instant start with no install, built-in billing, direct Instagram posting, 6 interface languages and phone editing. None of the plan below should weaken these.

Reuse: Apache-2.0 lets us adapt its code in our MIT project if we keep its licence and notices for those parts. Its name and logo are not covered. Check this properly before copying files; adapting ideas is the safer default.

LESSONS

Eight habits worth copying

These cost little and shape everything else, so they matter more than any single feature.

1 **Keep the story as data, not one giant prompt**
OpenManga states this as its founding idea: cast, scenes, pages and panel specs are stored, and prompts are built from them. Our project JSON already points this way. Each new fact (outfit, location) should be a field, not more prompt text.

2 **AI proposes, a person applies**
Bible extractions, narration fixes and video edits all wait on the job until someone confirms, often with a before and after. Make this our rule for every AI change to existing work.

3 **Never let a model draw what the app can draw**
Lettering, layout and headlines are composited by the app, so rewording costs nothing. We already do this with bubble layers. Hold that line, even when image models get better at text.

4 **Price it before running it**
Runs are priced first, then capped by budget, and new projects start with a $5 cap. Our estimate tools fit this. Extend it from single panels to whole runs.

5 **Protect consistency over convenience**
OpenManga deliberately refuses automatic image provider failover, because switching models mid-chapter breaks the look. If a render fails, stop and ask. Don’t quietly swap Anima for Klein.

6 **Version prompts like code**
Templates carry version numbers, and a test holds each version’s hash so nobody changes one by accident. A prompt change alters what paying users get, so it deserves the same care as code.

7 **Put limits on automatic spending**
Automatic re-rolls stop at 3, whatever the budget left. Any automation that spends credits needs a hard ceiling from day one.

8 **Write down what you won’t build**
Its roadmap has a “deliberately not built” table giving each reason and what would change it. That stops old debates returning, and it is free to adopt. The last page of this plan can be our first version.

PLAN OVERVIEW

Four phases, foundation first

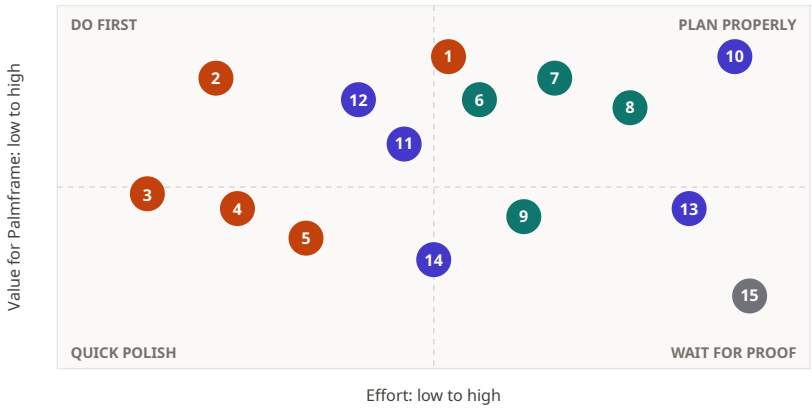
Phase 1 improves every carousel made today. Phase 2 deepens consistency. Phase 3 builds on both to spread the work further. Phase 4 is a bet to decide later.

Phase 1: Trust
Weeks 1 to 5
Foundation, then items 1 to 5

Phase 2: Consistency
Weeks 6 to 12
Items 6 to 9

Phase 3: Reach
Weeks 13 to 22
Items 10 to 14

Phase 4: Bet
After a review
Item 15



Phase 1 Phase 2 Phase 3 Phase 4

Foundation: do this before item 1

FIX	WHAT TO DO	EFFORT
Tests and CI	Cover credits, refunds and webhooks first, then pure logic such as `story.ts` and layouts. Run typecheck and tests on every push. Our last change went in with manual checks only.	M
A fake AI provider	OpenManga's mock mode lets the full pipeline run with no spend. We need one so tests never touch a GPU or a paid API.	S
Versioned prompts	Move prompts into named, numbered templates with a hash test, starting with the story planner.	S

Risks to watch

- **Feature creep.** OpenManga's breadth is the trap. Test every item against one question: does this make a better short comic?
- **Credit prices.** Checks and extra references add cost. Decide who pays before shipping items 1 and 8.
- **Project size.** Sheets, outfits and locations grow the project JSON that autosave sends. Measure this during phase 2.
- **Public links.** Item 11 is our first public view of user work, so it needs a security review and a way to report abuse.

PHASE 1

Trust: catch problems before the user does

1 Slide check

Effort M · High value

What it is A vision model reads each finished panel and reports who is in it, the headcount, any stray lettering, and a box around every face. OpenManga re-rolls a failed panel at most 3 times, inside the budget.

Why us Bad hands get forgiven; the wrong character does not. Today a person has to spot this on every slide, and a carousel of ten needs ten clean panels.

In our code New `api.check` route using the Anthropic client `api.story.ts` already has. Add a `panel_check` entry to `COSTS`. Store the verdict on the panel layer and badge it in the page strip.

2 Bubbles that know about faces

Effort S · High value

What it is Face boxes from the check aim each tail at the speaker and warn when lettering hides more than 30% of a face. Covered faces are flagged, never re-rolled, because the fix is moving text.

Why us Auto-lettering is where a generated page starts to look finished or look cheap. This gives a visible jump for little code.

In our code Extend `bubblesFor()` in `story.ts` to take optional faces. Port `tailTowardFace` and `coveredFaces` from `domain/bubbles.ts`. Needs item 1.

3 Shot variety warning

Effort S · Medium value

What it is A pure function flags 4 panels in a row at one shot size, or 3 at one size and angle.

Why us Repeated close-ups are the commonest tell of AI comics, and swiping makes them more obvious. It costs no credits.

In our code Read framing and angle from panel tags, the same ones `setup-panel.tsx` sets. Show a quiet note in the page strip.

4 Compare takes side by side

Effort S · Medium value

What it is Run one panel through several models, keep every result as a version, and pick the winner.

Why us We already keep takes and versions. Comparing Anima and Klein on the same shot helps people choose, and spend credits on purpose.

In our code A compare view over the existing versions list, plus “Try with the other engine”.

5 Pre-publish check

Effort S · Medium value

What it is Platform presets with published limits, checked before an export and after it. Every message names the number it checked.

Why us Failing at the Post button is the worst moment to learn about a limit.

In our code A small table of Instagram limits, checked in `publish-dialog.tsx`. Confirm the current limits; OpenManga’s own file warns they change.

PHASE 2

Consistency: one world across every slide

Each item here raises what we send to the image model, so show the credit cost wherever a choice changes it.

6 Layout guides

Effort M · High value

What it is Upload or draw a rough sketch or stick figures for a panel, set to loose or strict. In strict mode the sketch beats the written description on pose and framing, and never on identity or style.

Why us Words are a poor way to direct a pose. This gives people real control, and they pay for fewer re-rolls.

In our code Add to `PanelLayer`, starting on the Klein path, which already takes reference images. Send it large: OpenManga uses a lossless PNG up to 1024 px, because at 192 px a stick figure became a smudge. Anima needs its own route.

7 Outfits and approved sheets

Effort M · High value

What it is Sheets move from draft to approved to locked. Each outfit is redrawn from the approved sheet, told to change only the clothes.

Why us OpenManga found that without this baseline, every outfit drifted into a different face. Our `Character` has one sheet, so a costume change means a new character.

In our code Extend `Character` in `model.ts` with outfits and a status. Add a per-panel outfit pick to the cast controls in `cast.tsx`.

8 Locations and props

Effort M · High value

What it is Recurring places and objects get their own reference images, attached to a panel in a fixed order: characters first, the previous panel last.

Why us Character consistency is half the job. If the café changes on every slide, it still doesn't read as one story.

In our code A `world` list beside `cast` in `ComicProject`. Each attachment should show its credit effect, as these panels take the 20-credit `panel_ref` route.

9 Coverage sheet

Effort M · Medium value

What it is One image shows a moment from nine camera setups. Picked cells become strict layout guides.

Why us It lets people explore for the price of one image, then commit. It suits a credit model well.

In our code One new render type, a cell picker, and a handoff to item 6.

PHASE 3

Reach: more from every carousel

10 One-button carousel run

Effort L · High value

What it is From a story: plan, draw sheets, draw panels, letter, check. It skips what exists, prices the rest first, and pauses where you ask.

Why us This is the promise most users came for. The parts exist already, but the user has to run them in order.

In our code An orchestrator over the story planner, `generateAll` and item 1. Needs a server-side job so it survives a closed tab.

11 Reader links

Effort M · High value

What it is An unlisted, read-only, revocable link that opens without an account, swipeable, with no login wall.

Why us Every shared link shows the work to someone who hasn't seen Palmframe. It is the cheapest growth loop in this plan.

In our code A `share_token` on `comic_projects`, a public `/read/:token` route, and revoke in the Post dialog. Review the row-level security carefully.

12 Translated lettering

Effort M · High value

What it is Translate a carousel's lettering per language. Artwork stays; hand edits survive retranslation.

Why us The app already speaks 6 languages. One carousel becoming six posts needs no new image spend.

In our code A per-language text map on bubble layers, and a language switch in Export. Bubbles must refit, since German runs long.

13 Series memory

Effort L · Medium value

What it is A light story bible: cast, facts and character state carried across carousels, then checked against each new one.

Why us Instagram rewards recurring series. `recapOf` only remembers the slide before, inside one project.

In our code Start with shared cast across projects, then a facts list fed to the planner. Leave OpenManga's full continuity engine behind.

14 Scoped agent access

Effort M · Medium value

What it is Each agent connection has its own scopes and project list, and can wait for approval on spending or deleting. Tokens carry a snapshot, but current settings win.

Why us Our MCP route has 8 tools and our API keys have no scopes, so any key can spend all of its owner's credits.

In our code A `scopes` column on the API keys table, checked in `authenticate`. Add a per-key credit limit first; it is the piece that matters most.

PHASE 4 AND WHAT TO SKIP

One bet, and nine things to leave out

15 Narrated reel from a carousel

Effort L | Bet

What it is Slow pan and zoom over panels with a voiced script, cut to narration timing. OpenManga runs Kokoro locally at no API cost.

Why us We already have the 9:16 format and Instagram posting. Reels reach further than carousels, but this is a new media pipeline.

In our code Decide after phase 3. Prove demand first with a simple client-side animated export without voice.

Deliberately not building

A starting point for our own list. Each row says what would change the decision.

ITEM	WHY NOT	WHAT WOULD CHANGE IT
Self-hosting stack	Our edge is opening a link and starting	A paying customer needs private hosting
Many image providers	Our look depends on tuned Anima and Klein prompts	A better model replaces one outright
Paste-a-reply mode	Solves having no API key; credits solve this for us	Agents need it, though MCP is the better route
Small reference images	A saving for token-billed APIs; we don’t pay that way	We move to a token-billed image API
YouTube tools	Our audience publishes on Instagram	Item 15 succeeds and users ask for long video
Print and KDP tools	Deep work for a small share of our users	Users start selling printed collections
Hosted AI video models	High cost per clip, with hard pricing questions	Item 15 proves demand
Narration QA, timing	Only useful for long narrated videos	Long narrated video becomes a product
Comments, roles, review	Our users are mostly solo creators, as far as we know	Teams or agencies ask for it

Next step: start the foundation work this week, and review this plan when phase 1 ships.